The Helper Conversation

Civic Skill: Empathy | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 3 (Wellbeing) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will meet and interview a community helper whose work centres on caring for others, connecting the concept of empathy to adult civic roles and professional care.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can name at least one job that involves looking after other people.
- I can ask a question that starts with 'What do you do when...'
- I can explain why that job is important to our community.

MATERIALS

- A pre-arranged visitor: a nurse, paramedic, community volunteer, librarian, social worker, or firefighter
- Question cards prepared with children in advance (children dictate, educator writes)
- Paper for drawing/writing a thank-you response after the visit
- A 'community helpers' display to build over the program

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. PREPARATION SESSION (day before — 5 min): Tell children about the visitor. Together, generate questions. Educator writes them on cards. Focus on empathy-rich questions: 'What's the hardest part of your job?' 'How do you know what someone needs?' 'What do you do when you can't help?'

2. WELCOME AND INTRODUCTION (5 min): Children welcome the visitor. Educator models respectful greeting. Briefly explain: 'We have been learning about feelings and caring for others. Our visitor does that as their job every day.'

3. INTERVIEW (12 min): Children take turns asking their prepared questions. Educator gently prompts: 'Can you tell us about a time when someone really needed your help?' Allow genuine stories — don't sanitise.

4. CHILDREN RESPOND (5 min): 'What surprised you? What would be the hardest part of this job? Would you want to do it?' Validate complex responses — it's okay if children say it sounds too hard.

5. THANK YOU (3 min): Children draw or dictate a thank-you response. Display these as 'letters to our community helpers.'

EXTENSIONS

- Children 'apply' to be a class helper role for the week, describing what they'll do for others
- Create a 'helpers map' of the local community — who cares for people in our suburb?
- Invite families to share their own caring work — formal or informal

ASSESSMENT

- Observation: Did children ask questions that went beyond surface interest to genuine curiosity about the helper's experience?
- Written/drawn response: What did the child highlight? What resonated?
- Note: Which children expressed desire to help others themselves — a strong prosocial indicator

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- What did the visitor reveal about empathy in professional contexts that you hadn't anticipated?
- Did any child express discomfort with the idea of caring work? What might that reflect?
- How could you continue to make 'community care' visible in your everyday environment?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 3 (Wellbeing). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.